

What a difference a year made for State

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like the Edsel — you didn't know whether to laugh or cry or pray. The old doll joke went: Wind up a Bulldog and what does he do? He fumbles.

Emory Bellard didn't spend a whole lot of time laughing last December. When the recruiting season cooled down for Christmas, Bellard found himself sitting in his easy chair at home, puffing on his pipe and wondering how the hell a team with so many good football players could be so lousy. Three and eight? TCU goes 3-8, not Emory Bellard. Three and eight is for people who can't find a first down with a yard marker. Three and eight? Geez. Spare me, Lord.

It didn't take Bellard too many puffs to deduce that quarterback was the problem area. As a quarterback, Dwayne Brown was a good defensive back. You can't shoot a gun if you've got no trigger, right?

So John Bond, another in the Valdosta, Ga., quarterback assembly line, was recruited. The rest, as they say, is history. You can look it up. Nine and two, Sun Bowl bid. Beat Alabama. Beat Ole Miss. Won their last five games. Good case could be made for the 1980 bunch as State's best team since Babe McCarthy invented basketball.

John Bond lunched Friday with 1,100 people he didn't know, admired the boots he bought at Tony Lama's and talked about what a wonderful world it is. How wonderful? So wonderful, in fact, that he wanted to publicly thank the University of Southern Mississippi, which dog-whipped State, 42-14, in mid-season.

"That's what woke us up," Bond contends. "I'm going to remember it as long as I live."

The Golden Eagles didn't do anything but half kill Bond and beat the Bulldogs like they were unwashed puppies.

Thanks, guys.

Mississippi State looked like a real good candidate for a 5-6 season about that time. But the Bulldogs, Bond says, held a little meeting after the Southern game. "We decided we could be good or be bad," he says. Time to see if there was anybody around worth spittin' on.

They decided good was better.

A week later the Bulldogs beat Miami. Then it was Auburn, No. 1-ranked Alabama, LSU and Ole Miss. Today it is eighth-ranked Nebraska.

Nebraska wingback Anthony Steels played the piano and sang. Mississippi State fullback Steve Packer warbled about a Mississippi Delta cotton-picking town and Andy Cohen, an ex-major leaguer, prayed for the good Lord to take care of CBS-TV's Tommy Brookshier on both sides of the Rio Grande River.

It was the Sun Bowl luncheon and there's

hardly anything to compare with it unless you make a habit of inviting 1,100 people over for lunch.

Pat Summerall, Brookshier's CBS partner-in-the-booth, disclosed the little-known fact that a Mississippi State-Florida contest was the first college football game he ever saw. He remembered Blondy Black, a great running back for State. That got applause.

Emory Bellard addressed the prayer-giver, Andy Cohen. "That's the first time I've ever heard anyone pray for the coaches to enjoy tranquility and serenity." That also drew applause.

Today at 12:30 (Jackson time) on WJTV (Channel 12) the Bulldogs are hoping for more applause. Emory Bellard will coach, John Bond will quarterback, Mardye McDole will work his magic and Johnnie Cooks will tackle. Business as usual.

And business, folks, has been great.